



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Misogyny and Online Influence: A Guide for Parents

What it is, what to look for at different ages, how to talk about it at home, and how the school works with you.

Before You Read

This guide covers sexual harassment, sexual violence, image-based abuse and controlling relationships.

This guide covers misogyny, sexual harassment, sexual violence, nude image sharing and controlling relationships. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or your child's.

- Read it in sections and come back to it when you need to.
- If you are worried about your child, you can contact the school's safeguarding team at any time (details under **Who Can Help**).
- **NSPCC Helpline** (adults worried about a child): 0808 800 5000, 10am to 4pm, Monday to Friday.
- **Rape Crisis 24/7 Support Line** (ages 16 and over, including adults): 0808 500 2222.

If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Why We Have Written This Guide

Children and young people are growing up with a steady flow of online content about what it means to be a man or a woman. Some of it is harmless; some of it is openly misogynistic, and much of it is presented as humour, fitness or self-improvement. This guide explains what misogyny can look like at different ages, how online influence works, how to talk about it at home, and how the school works with you when there is a concern.

- **Most boys and young men are respectful** to girls, young women and each other.
- Girls are more likely to be the victims of sexual harassment and sexual violence, and it is more likely to be carried out by boys. **Anyone can be affected**, including boys and lesbian, gay, bisexual or gender-questioning young people, who may find it harder to tell someone.

- The aim is to challenge harmful ideas and behaviour, not to blame boys as a group or to alarm families.

Your children have their own guides: Student Guide 101 - 11 to 14 and Student Guide 101 - 14 to 18. You may find it helpful to read them together.

Key Words

Misogyny

Dislike of, contempt for, or prejudice against women and girls. It ranges from jokes and put-downs to beliefs that women are worth less than men.

Sexism

Treating someone unfairly because of their sex, for example "girls can't lead" or "boys don't cry".

Sexual harassment

Unwanted conduct of a sexual nature, in person or online: comments, jokes, touching, images or messages that make someone feel intimidated, degraded or humiliated.

Child-on-child abuse

The term schools use when harm is caused by one child or young person to another, including harassment, bullying and sexual violence.

Image-based abuse

Taking, sharing or threatening to share intimate images without consent, including AI-made "deepfakes" and sextortion (blackmail with images).

Coercive control

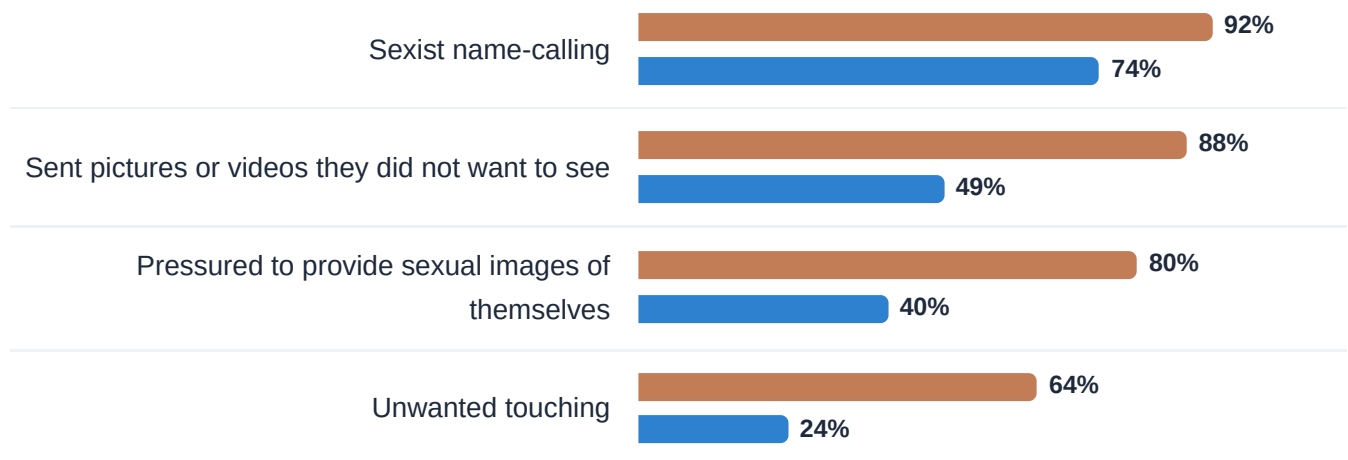
A pattern of controlling behaviour in a relationship: checking a phone, deciding who someone sees, making them afraid to disagree.

National guidance for schools is clear that sexual harassment should never be passed off as "banter", "just having a laugh", "a part of growing up" or "boys being boys" (Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026).

What the Evidence Shows

In schools and colleges: percentage of young people saying each happens "a lot" or "sometimes" to them or people their age.

■ Girls ■ Boys



Source: Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges*, 2021. These are young people's views of what happens among their peers.

49%

of 13 to 17 year olds who had been in a relationship in the past year experienced violent or controlling behaviour

Youth Endowment Fund, 2024

13

the average age at which young people first saw pornography; 59% first saw it by accident

Children's Commissioner, survey May 2025

13%

of children aged 9 to 17 had had an experience with a nude deepfake

Internet Matters, 2024

56%

of boys aged 6 to 15 had a negative view of a well-known misogynistic influencer. Most boys surveyed did not view him positively

YouGov, September 2023

Surveys ask different questions of different groups, so read each figure with its source. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges* (June 2021)

- Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024*: teenage relationships
- Children's Commissioner for England, pornography research (survey May 2025; published August 2025)
- Internet Matters, *The new face of digital abuse* (October 2024)
- YouGov Children's Omnibus (September 2023)
- Dublin City University Anti-Bullying Centre, *Recommending Toxicity* (summary report, 2024)
- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*

What It Can Look Like at Different Ages

The same ideas can look very different as children grow. These are examples to help you notice and ask, **not a checklist for labelling a child**. A single phrase is rarely a concern on its own; a change over time is worth a conversation.

Ages 4 to 9

Copied phrases and rules

- "Girls can't be the leader." "That's a boy job."
- "Boys don't cry"; teasing a boy for being upset
- Words picked up from older siblings, games or YouTube, often not understood
- "Girl" used as an insult
- Repeating a line from a video because it gets a laugh

Ages 10 to 13

Memes, jokes and ranking

- Calling boys "alpha", "beta" or "sigma" to rank them
- Sexist jokes shared "ironically" for laughs
- Rating girls' looks, or worrying about jawline, height or muscle
- "Girls get away with everything" turning into "feminism is the problem"
- Group-chat language spilling into school or home

Ages 14 to 18

A more fixed worldview

- Talk of a "sexual marketplace" or being "high value"
- Hopelessness: "there's no point trying"
- Jealousy or checking a partner's phone seen as normal
- Extreme gym, diet or supplement routines tied to worth
- Pile-ons, rumours or image sharing

Changes Worth a Conversation

- Growing hostility or contempt towards girls and women, or towards boys who don't fit a narrow mould
- Withdrawal from friends, family meals, sleep or activities they used to enjoy
- Secrecy about a new online community, or distress after being online
- Preoccupation with looks, status or money, or risky diet and body practices

- In relationships: controlling, possessive or pressuring behaviour, in either direction

Online Influence and the "Manosphere"

Much of this content now finds young people rather than the other way round. It arrives through sport, gaming, gym and motivational videos, often mixed with humour.

2 to 17 min

In a 2024 experiment, new accounts set up as teenage boys interested only in gym, sport and gaming were recommended manosphere content within 2 to 17 minutes

DCU Anti-Bullying Centre, 2024

76% / 78%

of recommendations were problematic or toxic by the final round, after about two to three hours of viewing (TikTok / YouTube Shorts)

DCU Anti-Bullying Centre, 2024

A small experiment with ten accounts, and platforms have changed since. It shows how recommendation can work, not what every child sees.

Decode the Feed

You don't need to know every term. Asking your child **"What does that mean to you?"** is more useful than pretending to know. Terms change quickly; this guide names no influencers, because the names change too.

Glossary (15 terms)

Term	What it usually means
Manosphere	A loose network of online communities and creators focused on masculinity, dating, status and perceived male disadvantage. Some strands are strongly anti-feminist; they do not all hold the same beliefs.
Manfluencer	A male influencer whose content centres on masculinity, status, money, relationships or self-improvement.
Red pill	Borrowed from <i>The Matrix</i> : supposedly "waking up" to hidden truths about gender, feminism and relationships.
Black pill	A fatalistic belief, common in some incel spaces, that looks and genetics decide romantic success and nothing can change it.
Incel	"Involuntary celibate": an online identity built around not having the relationships someone wants, often with resentment towards women.

Term	What it usually means
MGTOW	"Men Going Their Own Way": communities that advocate men withdrawing from relationships with women.
MRA	Men's Rights Activist. Online strands vary widely in tone and ideology.
PUA	Pick-Up Artist: a dating subculture teaching "techniques" and scripts to get attention from women.
Alpha / Beta / Sigma	Status labels used to rank boys and men. "Sigma" is widely used in memes and jokes, often by younger students.
High-value man (HVM)	Shorthand for a man with money, status and physique, often paired with claims that women's "value" falls with age. Watch for it being used to rank peers.
Top G	A status nickname that began as one prominent influencer's self-branding. Now used by students as a joke or a label for someone seen as dominant.
Looksmaxxing	Trying to maximise physical attractiveness. It ranges from ordinary grooming and fitness to risky practices, extreme dieting and unregulated products.
Mogging	Outshining or dominating someone, usually in looks or status ("he got mogged"). Used to rank and humiliate.
Mewing	A tongue-posture technique promoted with claims that it reshapes the jaw; those claims are not supported by robust evidence. Younger students also use the "mewing" gesture as a meme to avoid answering a question.
Tradwife	An online aesthetic built around highly traditional wife and mother roles. Not in itself manosphere content, but it can overlap with rigid gender ideology.

Why It Can Appeal

- **Belonging:** a group and a language, especially for a young person who feels left out.
- **Certainty:** simple rules for complicated questions about relationships and success.
- **Aspiration:** money, muscles and confidence made to look easy.
- **Humour:** jokes make ideas easier to repeat. Children can reject the creator and still repeat the ideas.
- **Earnings:** attention is turned into courses, products and subscriptions.

Wanting to belong and feel confident is normal. The conversation is about meeting those needs in ways that don't put anyone down.

The NOISE Check: Try It Together

A quick way to take a post apart with your child, without criticising them for watching it.

N

Negative

Which feelings does it use? Anger, shame, jealousy, "not good enough"

O

Oppositional

Who is set against whom? Men vs women, "us vs them"

I

Insecurity

Which worries does it profit from? Looks, money, dating, status

S

Simplistic

What is the too-easy answer? One fix; whole groups stereotyped

E

Earnings

Who makes money from the click, follow, course or product?



@PeakMale.Protocol

Made-up account · 1.2M views

Bro. 90% of guys are invisible to women. Why? Weak jaw. Weak mindset. No money.

Women only want the top 10%. Stop being the "nice guy". Start being HIGH VALUE.

My 30-Day Alpha Protocol fixes your face, your bank account and your dating life.

Link in bio. Only 50 places left.

We made this post up; the account does not exist. The "90%" is invented too, which is part of the point.

Suggested Answers

- **N:** "invisible", "weak jaw, weak mindset": uses shame and fear of rejection
- **O:** girls framed as judges who "only want the top 10%"; "nice guys" framed as losers
- **I:** looks, money and dating: three big worries in one post
- **S:** a made-up statistic, and one programme that "fixes" your face, money and love life
- **E:** a paid programme, link in bio, "only 50 places left" to rush you, and the view count to look popular



Talking with Your Child

Curiosity before confrontation. If your child repeats something that worries you, the aim is to keep them talking. A child who feels judged tends to stop telling you things, and to keep watching anyway.

Questions That Open Things Up

- "What does that mean to you?"
- "Where did you first see that?"
- "What do you like about them?"
- "How do you think a girl in your class would feel hearing that?"
- "Who makes money if people believe this?"
- "Show me what comes up on your feed."

What Tends to Backfire

- Arguing about the influencer, their wealth or their lifestyle
- Mocking the content or your child for watching it
- Banning without a conversation (it often moves the watching elsewhere)
- Treating one comment as proof of something serious
- Only talking about it when something has gone wrong

Say It Differently: Instinctive Replies and Alternatives

Instinctive reply	An alternative
"That's disgusting. Don't you ever say that again."	"That's a put-down of women and girls, and I don't want it said in our home. I'm curious though: where did you hear it?"
"You don't actually believe that, do you?"	"What makes that feel true to you?"
"Boys will be boys."	"I heard that. It's not OK, even as a joke. Let's talk about why it lands badly."
"Why would you watch rubbish like that?"	"Tell me what you like about it. I'd like to understand."
"He's a millionaire, so what does he know about real life?"	"Lots of people find that lifestyle impressive. What does being successful mean to you?"

Conversation Starters by Age

- **Ages 4 to 9:** "Can anyone be the leader? Can boys be gentle? Can girls be strong?" Stories and play where anyone can do anything.
- **Ages 10 to 13:** "What's funny about that video? Who might not find it funny?" Watch something together and try the NOISE check.
- **Ages 14 to 18:** "What do you think a good relationship looks like?" Talk about consent, respect and pressure, including online.

Short, regular conversations work better than one big talk. Car journeys and meals are often easier than face-to-face.

At Home

Practical Steps

- Know which apps and games your child uses, and ask them to show you how they work.
- Most apps let you mark videos as "not interested" and clear or reset watch history. Doing this together can change what the feed shows.
- Use parental controls and privacy settings suited to your child's age. Internet Matters has step-by-step guides for devices and apps.
- Agree family rules together, such as where devices are charged overnight and when screens go off.
- Model it: how adults at home talk about women, men, bodies and relationships is what children copy.

What All Parents and Carers Can Model

- **Every parent and carer** can model respect, talk about feelings, teach boundaries and consent, and challenge a sexist joke when they hear one, whatever their own gender.
- Help children of every gender know they can say no, speak up and be believed, and that respect and kindness are strengths.
- **Positive male role models** (fathers, uncles, coaches, older brothers, family friends) can have a particular influence on boys, alongside everyone else in their lives.
- Praise kindness, fairness and standing up for others as much as achievement.

Every Child, Every Family

- **Children with SEND** can be more at risk. Signs of harm can be mistaken for their needs, they may find it harder to tell someone, and some may repeat things they see online without understanding them. Ask the school how it will adapt, and whether the SENCO is involved.
- **Racism, religious hatred and misogyny often come together.** If your child is targeted for more than one reason, tell the school about all of it.
- If your child is lesbian, gay, bisexual, trans or questioning their gender, or others think they are, and they are being bullied or harassed, tell the school. Bullying and harassment should never be tolerated.
- If English is not your first language, you can ask the school for an interpreter. The school should explain its expectations and the law in England clearly and respectfully.

If Your Child Boards

- Ask the school how and when it will contact you, especially if you live in another time zone, and keep your contact details and your guardian's details up to date.
- If your child has an educational guardian, ask what the guardian will and won't be told.
- Boarders can always contact their house parents, the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night. They should also be able to contact you in private. They should also know the school's independent listener, and services such as Childline (0800 1111) and Help at Hand (0800 528 0731).
- Much online content is watched in the evenings. Ask about the house rules for devices, and keep talking: regular calls help you notice changes.
- If you're worried, contact the house parent or the safeguarding team straight away. Don't wait for the next visit home.

If Your Child Tells You Something

If Your Child Tells You Something Has Happened

- **Stay calm and listen.** Your calm is contagious. Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- Ask gentle open questions ("Tell me what happened"); avoid "why" questions, which can sound like blame.
- **Don't promise to keep it secret.** Explain that you may need to involve people who can help.

- **Don't confront the other child or their family, or post about it online.** It can make things harder for your child and for any investigation.
- Write down what your child said, in their words, and when, as soon as is practicably possible.
- Contact the school's safeguarding team. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

If Nude or Sexual Images Are Involved

- **Don't view, screenshot, save, forward or delete images**, even as evidence. Creating, keeping or sharing indecent images of anyone under 18 can be a criminal offence, including for adults trying to help, and including realistic AI-generated images. Leave it to the school and police, who follow safeguarding guidance.
- Tell the school, and they will follow national guidance.
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) helps under-18s get nude images of themselves removed online: Report Remove.
- If someone is threatening or blackmailing your child (sextortion): don't pay, don't reply, keep the account, and report to CEOP or the police.

Recognising Grooming, Coercion and Sextortion

- Someone, online or in person, an adult or an older young person, gives your child a lot of attention, flattery or gifts
- They ask your child to keep things secret, or move conversations to private or disappearing-message apps
- They push for photos, for more contact, or to meet up, and try to come between your child and their friends or family
- Pressure turns into threats or blackmail, often with urgency: "pay now or I'll share this"
- In your child you might notice secrecy about their phone, a new older "friend", unexplained money or gifts, or distress after being online

If you're worried, stay calm, don't blame your child, and contact the school or CEOP. Children often don't tell because they are ashamed or have been threatened.

If You're Worried About Your Child's Views or Behaviour

If you're worried about your child's views or behaviour, you are not alone, and asking for help early is the right thing to do. Children and young people can and do change, especially when the adults around them stay connected.

- Talk to your child's tutor, head of year or the school's safeguarding team. Schools would much rather hear early.
- **Stop It Now** (Lucy Faithfull Foundation): 0808 1000 900, confidential advice for parents worried about a young person's sexual behaviour. Monday to Thursday 9am to 9pm, Friday 9am to 5pm.
- **Shore** (shorespace.org.uk): anonymous support for teenagers worried about their own or someone else's sexual thoughts or behaviour. You can point your teenager to it.
- **NSPCC Helpline**: 0808 800 5000, for any adult worried about a child.

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice the signs, including online, and look for patterns
● Engage	Challenge harmful behaviour, if it is safe to do so, and listen to children
● Support	Make sure the child is safe and supported
● Pause	Stop and think about risk, rights and resources before acting
● Offer	Model alternatives and explain what happens next
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team as soon as is practicably possible
● Document	Record what happened, factually

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe**, not people to be blamed. You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you when there is a concern about your child, whether they have been harmed or have caused harm.
- It is common to feel shame, guilt, anger or fear when your child is involved, whether they have been harmed or have caused harm. Those feelings are normal, and you can ask for support for yourself too.

- If daytime meetings are hard because of work or caring, say so; schools can often offer another time or a call.
- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.
- Consequences for harmful behaviour sit alongside education and support, so that children can learn and change.
- Where appropriate, the school may involve local children's social care or the police. The school will explain what is happening wherever it can.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just banter"	If a child feels intimidated, humiliated or unsafe, it needs to be taken seriously and addressed; intention doesn't decide whether it's harassment. National guidance says it must never be dismissed as banter.
"My child is too young for this"	Children meet these ideas early, often through games, older siblings and video clips. Age-appropriate conversations can start in the early years.
"Banning the apps will solve it"	Controls help, but conversation matters more. Children who can talk to you are more likely to tell you when something goes wrong.
"Boys can't be victims"	Boys can be harassed, pressured, exploited

	or abused, and deserve support.
"Most boys agree with those influencers"	In one national survey, most boys had a negative view of a well-known misogynistic influencer. Algorithms can make this content look more popular than it is.
"Telling the school will make it worse"	The school can act to keep children safe, and will keep you informed wherever it can.



Who Can Help

At School

- Your child's tutor or advisor, head of year, or head of section
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **NSPCC Helpline** (adults worried about a child): 0808 800 5000, 10am to 4pm, Monday to Friday
- **Your local council's children's services**, if you are worried a child is at risk of harm. Search for your council's name and "report a concern about a child"; out of hours, councils run an emergency duty team
- **Stop It Now**: 0808 1000 900, confidential advice about harmful sexual behaviour
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, 24/7, or [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk)
- **Rape Crisis 24/7 Support Line** (16 and over): 0808 500 2222
- **CEOP** (ceop.police.uk): report online sexual abuse, grooming or sextortion
- **Internet Matters** (internetmatters.org): guides to parental controls and online safety
- **Support for you**: your GP, and your local council's family support services (search your council's name and "family help")
- **Emergency**: call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Misogyny and Online Influence: Parent Guide 101 - Ages 4 to 18

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